Decade Periodisation Plan 2026-2036 (annotated)

Version 2.1, 15 Oct 2026 (strength ladders rebuilt from the Oct 15 squat/deadlift tests and previous powerlifting bests). Every element carries an evidence tag, a rationale and citations. Re-plan every December.

Evidence tags

Tag	Meaning
STRONG	Meta-analysis, umbrella review or consensus statement supports it directly.
MODERATE	Individual trials, cohort/race-result data, or a meta-analysis applied one step beyond its population.
PRACTITIONER	Expert coaching consensus with little direct research. Reasonable, but not proven.
ASSUMPTION	My projection or judgement. No direct data exists; it says how it will be checked.

Tag count: STRONG 15, MODERATE 23, ASSUMPTION 9, PRACTITIONER 5 (of 52 elements).

A. The decade structure

Phase	Dates (age)	Primary	Maintained	Body comp
1. Foundation	Oct 2026 - Nov 2027 (22-23)	Aerobic base, Bangalore HM, Goa 70.3	Bench 100 attempt; heavy lower 2x/wk	Small cut, lean bulk, cut to 75-77, hold
2. Strength year	Dec 2027 - Nov 2028 (23-24)	Lifting toward Advanced; sprint baseline	Running 30-40 km/wk + 1 speed session	Bulk to ~80, cut to 77
3. Speed window	Dec 2028 - Nov 2031 (24-27)	Mile / 5K / 400 / 100 m	Heavy lifting 2x/wk; long run	75-77 kg @ 10-12%
4. Road + 70.3	Dec 2031 - Nov 2033 (27-29)	HM sub-1:25, marathon sub-3:00-3:10, 70.3 ~sub-4:35	Winter strength block	Race peaks 74-76 @ 9-11%
5. Capstone	2033 - 2037 (29-33)	Full Ironman, then Norseman	Strength 1-2x/wk	75-77 kg

Endurance-first hybrid identity

Plan: Primary goals are endurance (95th-percentile running and triathlon); lifting is held at the 80th percentile ('Advanced').

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [1], [4], [49], [50], [52], [60]

Lifting and endurance can coexist: across 43 studies adding aerobic work did not reduce maximal strength or hypertrophy gains [1], and an umbrella review of 144 studies found concurrent and single-mode training comparable for strength, hypertrophy and aerobic capacity [60]. The exception is lower-body strength in trained men (SMD -0.43) [4] and explosive strength (SMD -0.28) [1], which is why lifting is capped at Advanced rather than Elite. The endurance targets themselves come from race-result distributions [49][50][52].

One primary target per phase; everything else on a minimum dose

Plan: Each phase develops one quality hard and maintains the others with the minimum effective dose (1-2 heavy lifting sessions/week).

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [8], [9], [24], [55], [57]

One session a week with one hard set per exercise maintained 1RM for 8-32 weeks in 20-35-year-olds [8], and once-weekly heavy lifting preserved strength and thigh size in well-trained cyclists through a 13-week season [9]. Block periodisation of endurance shows small advantages (VO2max ES 0.40) but from short, low-quality studies [24]. No study tests decade-long goal sequencing, so the phase order itself rests on the peak-age data below; the principle of developing one quality while maintaining the others is also standard practitioner advice [55][57].

Strength year at 23-24, before the speed window

Plan: Dec 2027 - Nov 2028 is the main lifting block, not 27-31 as first drafted.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [7], [13], [18]

Classic powerlifters peak at about age 27 as a cohort and after 4-6 years of competing [13], so strength started at 23 is still rising at the speed-window age. Heavy strength also transfers to speed: non-specific strength and plyometric training improve sprint times (~2.6%) [18] and strength training improves maximal sprint speed in runners [7]. Lifting heavy first

therefore helps the next phase instead of competing with it.

Speed window at 24-27

Plan: Mile, 5K, 400 m and 100 m are the primary goals from Dec 2028 to Nov 2031.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [10], [11], [15]

World-class sprinters and middle-distance runners peak at about 24.5-25 [10][11]; speed and power peak earliest and decline first [11]. These are lifelong athletes, so the exact age carries uncertainty for an adult starter, but explosive qualities follow calendar age more than training age, unlike endurance [15].

Road and 70.3 time goals at 27-29

Plan: HM, marathon and fast 70.3 goals come after the speed window.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [10], [15], [44]

Marathon peak age is ~28-29 [10]; in 70.3 data, men under 30 are fastest [44]. Endurance development is driven by training years (elite athletes need 10-15 years) [15], so an athlete who started at 22 benefits from waiting. Running economy also keeps improving with years of running.

Norseman last, with ballot entries every year

Plan: First full Ironman ~2033, Norseman 2033-2037; enter the Norseman ballot every October from 2026.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [12], [47]

Ironman performance peaks at 32-35 in men [12]. Norseman places are a supply problem: 125 of 335 places go by ballot, tickets accumulate 1-2-3 over consecutive unsuccessful years and reset if a year is skipped or you are drawn [47]. Entering yearly from now maximises tickets by the early 30s. The 2027 ballot closes 11 Oct 2026 (23:59 CEST).

Annual re-plan and decision rules

Plan: Every December compare tests with the trajectories; more than 2 VDOT below 'likely' extends the phase; on the 'reach' path pulls targets forward.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [16]

Training response varies enormously between people (VO2max responses ranged from almost nothing to >1 L/min in HERITAGE) [16], so any decade plan must be re-anchored to measured results. The 2-VDOT threshold is my judgement: it is roughly one year of expected progress in the middle phases.

B. Projection models (what the targets are built on)

VDOT trajectory

Plan: Likely: 36 (now) -> 41 (2027) -> 43 (2028) -> 48 (2030) -> 51 (2032) -> 53 (2034). Reach: 36 -> 43 -> 46 -> 52 -> 55 -> 57.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [15], [58], [61]

There is no peer-reviewed data on yearly VDOT gains for adults who start running in their 20s; the research brief looked and flagged this gap. The path is built from: your measured novice gain (10K 1:07 in March to ~54-55 now, about +8 VDOT in 7 months) [61]; evidence that gains slow sharply toward the 650-900 h/yr plateau elite athletes reach after 10-15 years [15]; and smaller gains in the strength year when running drops to maintenance. All times are converted with the Daniels VDOT formula [58]. It will be checked against a mile and a 5K every year.

Mile speed bias

Plan: Mile targets add +2.5 VDOT to the trajectory.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [23], [58], [61]

Your estimated mile (~7:20) is VDOT 38.7 against ~36 for 10K-to-half fitness [61][58], consistent with your first sprint session (842 W, ~8.3 m/s) and a large anaerobic speed reserve, which characterises speed-type middle-distance runners [23]. Whether the bias persists as aerobic fitness grows is unknown; the annual mile test checks it.

Marathon padding

Plan: Marathon targets are 3-5% slower than the formula predicts from the half.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [17]

In a large sample of recreational runners, Riegel-type predictions were well calibrated from the mile to the half but too optimistic for the marathon [17]. A real marathon result will replace the estimate.

Strength ladders

Plan (likely path): Bench 96 (e1RM, Oct 2026) -> 98-100 (Feb 2027) -> 107-110 (Jul 2028) -> 112-114 (2030) -> 117 (2032). Squat 107 (e1RM, Oct 2026; previous best ~125) -> 120 (Dec 2026) -> 125-130 (Feb 2027) -> 145 (Jul 2028) -> 155-159 (2030). Deadlift 139 (e1RM, Oct 2026; previous best ~145) -> 148 (Dec 2026) -> 150-155 (Feb 2027) -> 170 (Jul 2028) -> 182-186 (2030).

Lift	e1RM Oct 2026	Previous best	Back to previous best (fast / likely / slow)	Lower-end Advanced (fast / likely / slow)
Bench	96	-	-	early 2029 / ~2031 / 2033-34
Squat	107	~125	Dec 2026 / Feb 2027 / spring 2027	late 2028 / ~2030 / ~2032
Deadlift	139	~145	Nov 2026 / Dec 2026 / Feb 2027	late 2028 / ~2030 / ~2032-33

Fast assumes the previous bests are back by Dec 2026, heavy lower 2x/wk in the bench block, gains held through the 70.3 year, and +15% in the strength year. Likely assumes +10-12% in the strength year, then +4-5% per winter block. Slow assumes +8%, then 3-4% a year.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [4], [14], [51], [61], [62], [63]

Strength lost in a layoff comes back faster than it was first built. After 30-32 weeks off, trained women's strength had not fallen to untrained levels, and 6 weeks of retraining quickly restored fast-fibre size [62]. Evidence for a lasting "muscle memory" advantage beyond that is mixed [63], and no study covers a 2-3-year layoff, so the climb back to your previous bests (squat ~125, deadlift ~145 [61]) is an estimate. Beyond those bests, rates fall to normal intermediate levels: competitive powerlifters gain ~7.5-12.5% in year one and ~20% over ten years [14], and lower-body gains are blunted under concurrent training [4]. Most new-territory progress is therefore placed in lifting-priority blocks (the Dec-Feb bench block, the strength year, winter blocks). Bench gets no retraining credit: it has been trained continuously at 84-96 kg since March [61]. Advanced (80th percentile) at 75-80 kg is bench 117-124, squat 159-168, deadlift 186-196 [51]. The lower end applies at ~75 kg (about 124 / 168 / 196 at 80 kg), so test at 76-77 kg rather than at the ~80 kg bulk peak.

Sprint ladder

Plan: 100 m: timed baseline in Apr 2027, -2-3% by 2028, 12.6-12.9 (likely) / 12.3 (reach) by 2030; sub-12.0 is a dream goal.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [1], [18]

Specific sprint training improves times by about 3.2% per intervention, non-specific strength/plyometric training by about 2.6% [18]. Sub-12.0 from an estimated 13.5 s is ~11% faster and needs a top speed of roughly 9.3-9.6 m/s, while endurance training blunts explosive qualities [1]. The 13.5 s starting point is a GPS estimate, so no target is firm until a timed 30 m fly and 100 m exist.

C. Phase 1 - Foundation (Oct 2026 to Goa 70.3, Nov 2027)

Meso	Dates	Focus	Weekly shape	Nutrition	Targets (likely / reach)
1.1	Oct 6 - Dec 20 2026	Namma 10K, mile TT, Bangalore HM	Garmin Coach runs T/Th/Sa/Su; lift M/W/F; swim Mon/Wed AM + weekend	Maintenance; gentle cut 0.3-0.5%/wk once sleep >=7 h	NICE 10K 56:00-57:30 / sub-56; mile 7:15-7:30 / sub-7:10; HM 2:02-2:06 / sub-2:00; squat e1RM 120 / 125; deadlift 148 / 155
1.2	Dec 21 - Feb 14	Bench 1RM test (Feb 8-14)	Lift 4x (bench heavy + volume); run 3x easy + strides; swim 2x	Lean bulk +0.25-0.4%/wk	Bench 98-100 / 102.5; squat 125-130 / 135; deadlift 150-155 / 160
1.3	Feb 15 - Apr 25	Cut; start cycling; rebuild running	Run 3-4x (30-45 km); bike 2-3x Z2; swim 2-3x; lift 2x	Cut 0.5-0.7%/wk to 76-77 kg	5K 23:00-24:00 / sub-22:40; first timed 100 m + 30 m fly
1.4	Apr 26 - Jul 31	70.3 base	Swim 3, bike 3 (long ride to 3 h), run 4 (40-55 km), lift 2; 3:1 loading	Maintenance; carbs to load	Optional Olympic tri 2:40-2:55
1.5	Aug 1 - Goa 70.3	70.3 build, bricks, heat, taper	Swim 3, bike 3, run 3-4, lift 1-2; 2-wk taper	Maintenance at 75-77; race fuel 60-90 g/h	Goa 70.3 5:50-6:20 / sub-5:35

Separate sessions: cardio in the morning, lifting later or on non-run days

Plan: Never pair hard intervals and heavy legs in one session; keep >=3-6 h between sessions on the same day.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [1], [2], [53], [54], [55], [56], [59]

In trained lifters, lower-body strength gains were blunted when both modes were in the same session (ES -0.66) but not when sessions were more than 2 h apart (ES -0.10) [2]; explosive-strength interference was concentrated in same-session designs and disappeared at >=3 h apart [1]. If both are unavoidable in one session, lifting first protects strength (+6.9%) [59]. Practitioners differ here: OMNIA's example weeks pair lower-body lifting with intervals on the same day [53] and Nick Bare's programme runs daily doubles [54]; those only fit the evidence with hours between sessions, which is what Viada and Stronger by Science recommend (6-8 h) [55][56].

Heavy, low-rep lower-body lifting during run blocks

Plan: Squat/hinge at >=80% 1RM, 3-5 reps, 4-8 hard sets/week.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [5], [6], [7]

Heavy loads improve running economy across 8.6-17.9 km/h, while 40-79% loads and isometrics did not [5], and high-load training improves time-trial performance [6]. Strength work improves economy and time trials without changing VO2max or body composition [7]. Keeping volume low limits the fatigue that interferes with running.

Weekday swim on Monday or Wednesday morning, not Friday

Plan: Protect the Friday upper/bench session from lat and shoulder fatigue.

Evidence: PRACTITIONER · Sources: [56], [57]

No trial tests swim placement relative to bench sessions. The rationale is fatigue management: swimming loads the same lats and shoulders as the upper session, and practitioners recommend separating overlapping sessions as far as possible [56][57]. Low stakes; adjust if Friday sessions feel fine.

Weekly fresh-day strides or flys

Plan: 6-8 x 60-80 m at full recovery once a week, never after lifting.

Evidence: PRACTITIONER · Sources: [1], [8], [20]

There is no direct trial of minimum sprint doses for maintaining speed in endurance athletes. The idea extends minimal-dose evidence from strength [8] and the observation that endurance work blunts explosive qualities [1]. Elite sprint programming organises speed work on fresh days with full recovery [20].

HM block stays with Garmin Coach; targets from current fitness

Plan: Bangalore HM Dec 20: 2:02-2:06 likely, sub-2:00 reach.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [17], [58], [61]

The targets come from your measured tempo (4x5 min at 5:35-5:40 at threshold HR) and estimated VDOT ~36 [61], converted with the Daniels formula [58]. Formula predictions are well calibrated up to the half marathon [17]. Run programming stays with Garmin Coach, your considered choice, through the race.

No calorie deficit while average sleep is under ~7 h

Plan: Cut only once the weekly sleep average reaches 7 h; target >=7.5 h.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [33], [34], [35], [61]

In a controlled deficit, 5.5 h vs 8.5 h of sleep meant 55% less fat lost and 60% more fat-free mass lost [33]; one night of sleep loss reduced muscle protein synthesis by 18% [34]. Sleep extension to ~8.5 h improved sprint times and skill in athletes [35]. Your average has been ~6.1-6.3 h [61], so dieting now would cost muscle.

Bench block: higher upper-body volume, then peak

Plan: Dec 21 - Feb 14: upper body 12-14 sets/muscle/week for 5 weeks, 2 weeks of heavy singles/doubles, test week Feb 8-14.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [25], [26], [61]

Hypertrophy rises with weekly sets (~0.37% per added set; >=10 sets/week is the practical benchmark) [25], and both size and strength increase with volume, with strength showing stronger diminishing returns and benefiting from frequency [26]. Your current 2 sets/exercise is below that for pressing muscles [61]. The heavy weeks before the test follow the specificity principle; their exact structure is practitioner convention.

Lean bulk during the bench block

Plan: +0.25-0.4% bodyweight/week (to ~79-80 kg).

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [27], [30]

A 10-20% surplus gaining about 0.25-0.5% of bodyweight per week is the recommended rate for novice-intermediate lifters to limit fat gain [27]. Protein near 1.6 g/kg is the point beyond which extra protein adds little muscle [30].

Bench target 98-100 likely, 102.5 reach

Plan: Feb 2027 1RM test.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [14], [61]

From an e1RM of 96 (70x11, Oct 14 2026) [61], 98-100 by the Feb test needs +2-4% from eight weeks of surplus and higher volume, consistent with typical intermediate gains [14]. 102.5 needs about +7%, faster than powerlifters' yearly average [14] and plausible only if the surplus and sleep both go well. A tested single usually lands a little below a high-rep e1RM.

Cut at 0.5-0.7%/week after the bench test

Plan: Feb 15 - Apr 25 to 76-77 kg; protein 150-180 g/day.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [28], [29]

Elite athletes losing 0.7%/week gained lean mass (+2.1%) and kept strength and sprint gains, while 1.4%/week lost lean mass [28]. In lean resistance-trained athletes, 2.3-3.1 g/kg fat-free mass protein is recommended during a deficit [29] (about 150-200 g for your ~65 kg lean mass).

Start cycling in February; get a road bike and trainer

Plan: Bike 2-3x/week Z2 from Feb 2027, long ride building to 3 h by July.

Evidence: PRACTITIONER · Sources: [44]

Goa is a 1.9 km swim, 90 km bike and 21.1 km run [44]; the bike is the longest leg and you have no cycling history. Training specificity means the 90 km cannot be prepared on a gym bike alone (no bricks, handling or outdoor pacing). The exact build is practitioner convention, not tested.

80/20 intensity distribution in the triathlon base

Plan: About 80% of sessions easy, 20% threshold or harder.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [21], [22]

World-class middle-distance runners do about 80% of sessions at low intensity in a pyramidal pattern [21]. A meta-analysis found polarised training better for VO2peak only in short interventions in highly trained athletes, with time trials similar across distributions [22], so the low-intensity majority is supported while strict polarised vs pyramidal is not settled.

3 weeks loading, 1 week lighter

Plan: Run and triathlon mesocycles use 3:1 loading; lifting deloads every 4-6 weeks.

Evidence: PRACTITIONER · Sources: [42]

A Delphi consensus of strength coaches describes deloads of about 7 days every 4-6 weeks, cutting volume first [42]; it is expert consensus, not trial evidence. 3:1 endurance loading is common coaching practice with no direct trial support. Garmin Coach applies its own adaptive easy weeks.

Energy availability on big training days

Plan: Eat to the day's training load; avoid flat 2,500 kcal on long-run and brick days.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [31], [32], [61]

Energy availability of ~45 kcal/kg fat-free mass/day approximates balance and <30 is associated with impairments [31]; in males the threshold may be lower but REDs risk is real [32]. At ~65 kg lean mass, a heavy training day at 2,500 kcal approaches that line [61]. Low energy availability and iron deficiency overlap in the REDs model [32], which matters given your ferritin of 27.

Optional Olympic-distance tune-up in the 70.3 base

Plan: One Olympic-distance race (1.5 / 40 / 10 km) in summer 2027, target 2:40-2:55.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [46]

A shorter race rehearses transitions, open-water swimming and pacing before Goa. In age-group Olympic-distance data the men's average is about 2:53 and the top 20% is around 2:35 [46]; 2:40-2:55 places a first-year triathlete near the average, consistent with the Goa projection. Whether to race it is your call; the evidence for tune-up races specifically is practitioner experience.

Two-week taper before key races

Plan: Cut volume 41-60% over 2 weeks, keep intensity.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [39]

A meta-analysis found the best taper lasts ~2 weeks with volume reduced exponentially by 41-60% and no reduction in intensity (volume-reduction effect size 0.72) [39].

Race fuelling 60-90 g carbohydrate per hour

Plan: Practise in long rides and bricks from August; glucose + fructose mixes.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [40]

Glucose absorption saturates around 60 g/h; glucose-fructose mixtures raise exogenous carbohydrate oxidation to ~90 g/h, recommended for events over 2-2.5 h, with less fatigue and better performance [40]. A 70.3 lasts ~6 h for you.

Heat acclimation before Goa

Plan: 10-14 days of training in heat before race week (Bengaluru afternoons work).

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [41]

Most heat adaptations (heart rate, core temperature, sweat rate) occur in the first week and are complete by 10-14 days; sessions should be >=30 min on consecutive days [41].

Goa 70.3 target 5:50-6:20 likely, sub-5:35 reach

Plan: First 70.3, November 2027.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [44], [61]

Built from: swim ~45-48 min (1.9 km at your CSS-based endurance pace of ~2:26/100 m [61]); bike ~3:00-3:20 for a first-year cyclist (my assumption, no data); run ~1:55-2:05 off the bike in heat; transitions ~8 min. The men 25-29 median is 5:39:26 and the whole-field top 25% is under 5:16:29 [44], so the reach target is around the median, appropriate for a first attempt.

DEXA scan before the February cut

Plan: One DEXA scan for a lean-mass/fat baseline.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [43]

Consumer bioelectrical impedance scales systematically underestimate fat mass and overestimate fat-free mass compared with DXA [43], so body-composition targets set from your BIA scale (~16% fat) could be off by several percent.

D. Phase 2 - Strength year (Dec 2027 - Nov 2028)

Meso	Dates	Focus	Shape	Nutrition	Targets (likely / reach)
2.1	Dec 2027 - Mar 2028 (16 wk)	Hypertrophy	4-day P/A/P/A, 12-16 sets/muscle; run 3x (25-35 km) + strides; swim 1-2x	Lean bulk +0.25%/wk to ~80 kg	Week-1 re-test: squat, deadlift, pull-up 3-5RM (baselines set Oct 2026)

Meso	Dates	Focus	Shape	Nutrition	Targets (likely / reach)
2.2	Apr - Jul 2028 (16 wk)	Strength + acceleration	4-day, 6-10 sets, 3-6 reps, 4-wk waves; sprint 1x/wk; run 3x	Maintenance ~80 kg	Bench 107-110 / 114; squat 145 / 158; deadlift 170 / 184; pull-up +30 / +40 kg
2.3	Aug - Nov 2028 (14 wk)	Cut, rebuild running, sprint test	Lift 3x; run 4x (35-50 km); sprint 1x	Cut 0.5-0.7%/wk to 76-77	Mile 6:15-6:30 / sub-6:00; 100 m -2-3% vs 2027

Four lifting days (P/A/P/A) with 12-16 sets per muscle in the hypertrophy block

Plan: Double frequency and raise volume while running drops to maintenance.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [25], [26], [57], [61]

Muscle growth rises with weekly set volume [25][26] and strength benefits from training frequency [26]. Endurance training hurts gaining muscle more than keeping it [57], so the year with the lowest running volume is the one to push hypertrophy. Your own split document already names P/A/P/A as the better programme for off-season [61].

Strength block with heavy waves and planned deloads

Plan: 3-6 reps, top sets at RPE 8-9, 4-week waves, deload every 4-6 weeks.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [26], [42]

Strength responds to heavier loads with steeper diminishing returns on volume than hypertrophy [26]. Deload timing follows the strength-coach consensus [42]. The specific wave structure is practitioner convention.

Acceleration and resisted sprints once a week

Plan: Short accelerations (10-30 m), resisted sprints, full recovery.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [18], [19], [20]

Resisted sprints have a large effect on short sprint times (ES -1.39) [18] and improve 10 m acceleration but not maximum velocity [19]. Elite sprint training builds acceleration first, then maximum velocity [20]. Pairing it with the strength year uses the strength gains as they arrive.

Running kept at 30-40 km/week

Plan: Three runs a week, mostly easy, plus strides.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [3], [8]

Interference with strength grows with endurance frequency and duration [3], so cutting running volume during the strength year reduces it. The exact volume needed to hold aerobic fitness is not well established; this is a conservative judgement backed by the general minimal-dose principle [8].

Bulk to ~80 kg, then cut to 77

Plan: +0.25%/week for 16 weeks, then 0.5-0.7%/week.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [27], [28]

Same evidence as Phase 1: recommended gain rates [27] and slow cut rates that preserve lean mass and strength [28].

E. Phase 3 - Speed window (Dec 2028 - Nov 2031)

Meso (yearly)	Focus	Shape	Nutrition
Winter base (16 wk)	Aerobic volume + max strength	Run 5x (50-65 km, 80/20, 1 threshold); lift 2x heavy; short sprints 1x; swim 1-2x	8-10 wk lean bulk early, then maintenance
Spring speed (8 wk)	VO2 + speed endurance	Run 5x: VO2 intervals, threshold, 150-300 m reps, long run; lift 2x power; max-velocity sprints 1x	Trim to 75-77 @ 10-12%
Summer race season (10-12 wk)	Mile, 5K, 400, 100 m races	Race every 2-3 wk; 1 sharpening session; lift 1-2x	Race weight 75-76
Autumn (8-10 wk)	Recovery, fun HM or 70.3, Norseman ballot	Aerobic, free choice	Maintenance

Track-style year: base, speed, race season

Plan: Repeat the winter-spring-summer-autumn cycle for three years.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [21]

This follows how world-class 800/1500 m runners are trained: a high-volume, mostly low-intensity base, with specific speed endurance closer to competition [21]. The 1500 m is 75-85% aerobic [21], so the base is not optional even for speed goals.

Speed endurance and max-velocity work in spring

Plan: 150-300 m reps plus one max-velocity session a week.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [20], [23], [61]

Elite sprint training progresses from acceleration to maximum velocity to speed endurance [20]. Speed-type 800 m runners (large anaerobic speed reserve) benefit most from lactate-tolerance work, endurance types from more aerobic volume [23]; your profile is speed-type [61].

Lifting held at 2 heavy sessions a week

Plan: Maintain and slowly build strength while speed is the priority.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [5], [7], [8], [9], [18]

Minimal doses maintain strength for months [8][9], and heavy strength supports both running economy [5] and sprint speed [7][18].

Speed-window targets

Plan: 2031 (age 27): mile 5:35-5:45 / sub-5:15; 5K 20:00 / sub-19:00; 400 m 59-61 / sub-57; 100 m 12.4-12.7 / sub-12.2.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [18], [49], [58]

Times follow the VDOT trajectory (section B) with the mile speed bias [58]. The 95th-percentile mile of 5:08 corresponds to VDOT ~58 [49], above even the reach path, so it remains a dream goal. Sprint targets assume ~3% improvement per dedicated block [18].

F. Phase 4 - Road and 70.3 speed (Dec 2031 - Nov 2033)

Winter strength block for the Advanced lower-body targets

Plan: 10-12 weeks of 3-4 lifting days with running at 40-50 km easy.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [2], [4]

Lower-body strength gains are blunted under concurrent training in males (SMD -0.43), especially trained ones [4][2], so heavy squat and deadlift progress is scheduled in a block where running is reduced rather than chased alongside run peaks.

Spring road build to a marathon or half

Plan: Run 5-6x/week, 60-80 km, marathon long runs to 32-35 km.

Evidence: PRACTITIONER · Sources: [15]

Long-run distances of 30-35 km are standard marathon coaching practice; I found no trial defining the optimum. Weekly volume follows the evidence that endurance development tracks accumulated volume [15]. This block needs your current 'no running past 21 km' rule lifted first.

Race weight 74-76 kg at 9-11% for A-races only

Plan: Short cut into each A-race; not held year-round.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [28], [36], [37]

Percent body fat (not BMI) predicted recreational marathon times alongside training speed [36] and was associated with Ironman times in men [37]. Both are cross-sectional, so the individual benefit is smaller than the slopes suggest [36]. The cut follows the 0.5-0.7%/week rate [28].

Road and 70.3 targets

Plan: 2033 (age 29): HM 1:28:30 / sub-1:25; marathon 3:05-3:10 / sub-3:00; 70.3 4:50-5:05 / sub-4:35.

Evidence: ASSUMPTION · Sources: [17], [44], [50], [52], [58]

From the VDOT trajectory [58] with marathon padding [17]. Benchmarks: race-population 95th percentile HM <1:25 and marathon <3:10 [50]; only 4% of male marathoners break 3:00 [52]; 70.3 whole-field top 10% is under 4:47:53 [44]. A men-only top 5% is not published, so ~4:35 is my extrapolation.

G. Phase 5 - Capstone (2033 - 2037)

First full Ironman before Norseman

Plan: 2033, autumn: finish 11:00-12:00 likely, sub-10:30 reach.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [45]

In 795,982 Ironman results, the whole-field median is 12:23:31, the top 25% is under 11:05:57 and the top 10% under 10:07:50; men 25-29 have a median of 11:49:02 [45]. A first Ironman around the top quarter is consistent with the fitness projected by then.

Norseman: finish, aiming for the black T-shirt

Plan: Black T-shirt = first 160 to reach 37 km (Stavsro); check the current race manual.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [12], [48]

The course is a 3.8 km fjord swim (as cold as 10 C), 180 km bike with over 3,000 m of climbing and a marathon to Gaustatoppen [48]. Ironman performance peaks at 32-35 [12]. No systematic data on finishers' backgrounds exists; specific preparation (climbing, cold water, steep trails) is practitioner advice.

H. Body composition across the decade

Window	Weight	Body fat	Phase
Now (Oct 2026)	79-80	~16-18% (BIA)	-
Dec 20 2026	77.5-78	~15%	small cut
Feb 2027	79-80	~15-16%	lean bulk
Apr - Nov 2027	75.5-77	12-13%	cut, then hold
Mar 2028	~80	13-15%	bulk
Nov 2028 - 2031	75-77	10-12%	home weight
A-race peaks 2032-33	74-76	9-11%	race weight

Home weight 75-77 kg at 10-12% fat

Plan: Target fat-free mass index ~19.7-20.7 at 182.9 cm.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [36], [37], [38]

The target requires roughly +0-3 kg lean mass and -6 to -9 kg fat. The resulting FFMI sits below the drug-free mean of 21.8 [38], so it is achievable naturally. Lower body fat predicts faster marathon and Ironman times [36][37].

Rates of change

Plan: Cut 0.5-0.7%/week; gain 0.25-0.5%/week.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [27], [28]

Slow cuts preserve lean mass and performance [28]; recommended lean-gain rates limit fat gain [27].

Protein

Plan: 150-180 g/day throughout; top of the range in deficits.

Evidence: STRONG · Sources: [29], [30], [31]

1.2-2.0 g/kg/day for athletes, higher in deficits [31]; hypertrophy benefit plateaus near 1.6 g/kg [30]; 2.3-3.1 g/kg fat-free mass in lean athletes during deficits [29].

I. Testing calendar

When	Test	Purpose
Every October	Norseman ballot; mile time trial	Ballot tickets; speed check
Every December	Annual review: year's best race as VDOT vs trajectory; DEXA if possible; ferritin	Re-plan
Every April	5K time trial; 30 m fly + 100 m (timed); swim CSS	Aerobic and speed markers
End of strength blocks	1RM/3RM bench, squat, deadlift, weighted pull-up	Strength ladder

Annual race-based tests

Plan: Mile and 5K each year, converted to VDOT.

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [16], [17], [58]

Race-time equivalence is well calibrated between the mile and the half marathon [17], so a mile and a 5K give a reliable VDOT read [58] to compare with the trajectory. Training responses vary widely between individuals [16], so measured results must drive the plan.

Ferritin recheck

Plan: December each year (first recheck ~Dec 2026).

Evidence: MODERATE · Sources: [32], [61]

Your ferritin was 27 (iron deficiency without anaemia) in Sep 2026 [61]; low energy availability and iron deficiency interact in the REDs model [32], so iron status is tracked alongside training load.

J. Goal ladder (likely / reach)

Goal	Dec 2027 (23)	Dec 2028 (24)	2030 (26)	2032 (28)	2034 (30)
VDOT (likely / reach)	41 / 43	43 / 46	48 / 52	51 / 55	53 / 57
Mile	6:35 / 6:20	6:20 / 6:00	5:47 / 5:24	5:30 / 5:09	5:20 / 5:00
5K	23:35 / 22:40	22:40 / 21:25	20:40 / 19:15	19:35 / 18:20	19:00 / 17:50
Half marathon	1:48 / 1:44	1:44 / 1:38	1:35 / 1:28	1:30 / 1:24	1:27 / 1:22
Marathon (padded)	-	-	-	3:15 / 3:00	3:07 / 2:55
70.3	6:05 / 5:35	-	5:15 / 4:55	5:05 / 4:45	4:55 / 4:35
Bench	98-100 / 103	107-110 / 115	112-114 / 117	117 / 120	117-120 / 124
Squat	125-130 / 137	145 / 159	155-159 / 168	159-165 / 168	159-168 / 168+
Deadlift	150-155 / 162	170-175 / 186	182-186 / 196	186-190 / 196	186-196 / 196+
100 m	baseline	-2-3%	12.6-12.9 / 12.3	maintain	-
Bodyweight	76-77	76-77	75-77	74-76 (race)	75-77

ASSUMPTION: the ladder is the VDOT and strength trajectories in section B converted to times [58][17]. The 95th-percentile line it aims at comes from race and lift distributions [49][50][51][52]: 5K sub-19, 10K sub-39, HM sub-1:25, marathon sub-3:00-3:10, mile sub-5:08, 70.3 ~sub-4:35, with Advanced lifting (bench 117-124, squat 159-168, deadlift 186-196). On the likely path most race-population marks arrive at ~29-31; on the reach path at ~27-28.

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